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FOR THE PEOPLE

The history of India's efforts to build a welfare state, paving the path to freedom, opportunity and justice for all citizens, is both uplifting and sobering. Uplifting because the very fact that the welfare state exists is a triumph of democracy. Democracy ensured that the voices and interests of India's last citizens were heard. But the sobering truth: the battle has been long, hard and continues still. Even 75 years after Independence, India spends far less on welfare programmes—health, education and social protection—than other economies comparable to it. Investments in welfare schemes are regularly derided as 'freebies' rather than welcomed as the moral responsibility of a state, and schemes remain plagued with poor governance and implementation. Nonetheless, the battle 'of, for and by' the last citizen has fuelled audacious experiments in which governments, in the states and at the Centre, and civil society have played a vital role. The evolution of India's welfare state tells the story of the power and possibility of democratic participation—one that has shaped national and global discourse. Here, I celebrate 10 of the best of these.



NAMAS BHOJANI

Total Literacy Campaign

Hunger Challenge

Food security is the foundation of India's welfare state. Distribution of foodgrains through the Public Distribution System (PDS) and hot, cooked midday meals (MDM) are its vital pillars. Once seen as emblematic of the corrupt state, the PDS—whose roots lie in the Green Revolution—saved India through the pandemic and its aftermath. Dating back to 1920s Tamil Nadu, the MDM today feeds nearly 110 million schoolchildren daily across India. Credited with significantly improving school enrolments, the MDM is a critical tool for tackling our malnutrition challenge.



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